

Project Evaluation and Communication

Module-7

Project Evaluation and Communication

- Project evaluation is the **process of measuring the success** of
 - an individual project,
 - a programme or
 - a portfolio of projects.
- It involves
 - gathering data about the project and
 - using an evaluation method
- It would **enable evaluators to find performance improvement opportunities.**

Project Evaluation and Communication

- Project evaluation is a step-by-step process of **collecting, recording and organizing information** about project results
- The above information includes
 - **short-term outputs** (immediate results of activities, or project deliverables), and
 - **long-term project outcomes** (changes in behaviour, practice or policy resulting from the project).

Why is Project Evaluation important?

Evaluating project results is helpful in providing answers to key questions like:

- What progress has been made?
- Were the desired outcomes achieved? Why?
- Are there ways that project activities can be refined to achieve better outcomes?
- Do the project results justify the project inputs?

Effective evaluation requires **clear objectives and metrics**, and communication is essential throughout the project lifecycle for **transparency, decision-making, and continuous improvement**.

Common rationales for conducting an evaluation are:

- Demonstration of **effective, efficient and equitable use of financial** and other resources;
- Recognition of **actual changes and progress made**;
- **Identification of success factors, need for improvement** or where expected outcomes are unrealistic;
- **Response to demands** for accountability;
- Validation for project staff and partners that desired outcomes are being achieved.

What are the Challenges in Monitoring and Evaluation?

- Getting the commitment to do it;
- Establishing **base lines at the beginning of the project;**
- Identifying realistic quantitative and qualitative indicators;
- Finding the time to do it and sticking to it;
- Getting feedback from the stakeholders;
- Reporting back to the stakeholders.

Types of Project evaluations

- Types of Project evaluations are based on
 - **timing** (formative, process, and summative) or
 - **by purpose** (impact, cost-effectiveness, and outcome).

Timing:

- Formative evaluation
 - It is **done at the start** to improve design,
- Process evaluation
 - It **monitors ongoing** implementation
- Summative evaluation
 - It **assesses overall success at the end.**
- Outcome evaluation
 - It **assesses the outcome of the project at the end**

By purpose:

- **impact** long-term effects evaluation
- **cost-effectiveness** evaluation (value for money),
and
- **outcome evaluation** (short-term changes).

Objectives of Project Evaluation

Project evaluation is undertaken for fulfilling one or more of the following types of objectives:
Effectiveness, Efficiency and Impact

- Effectiveness:
 - How effective is the development project?
 - Did it achieve the goals it set out to achieve?
 - The degree of objective intended results?

Objectives of Project Evaluation

- Efficiency:
 - This relates to **efficient utilization of financial and other resources** with available/fixed time to produce results with the least amount of wastage and deviation.
- Impact:
 - This is a measure of overall project's results, which actually work to alleviate or reduce the development problems, which originated the idea for the project in the first instance.

Project Evaluation Criteria

- The specific details of the project evaluation criteria vary from one project or one organization to another
- Influencing factors for the above include **risk tolerance, project management maturity, strategic planning** among many other aspects of the organization.
- In general terms, a project evaluation process goes over the project constraints including time, cost, scope, resources, risk and quality.
- In addition, organizations may add their own business goals, strategic objectives and other project metrics.

A typical framework for project evaluation

The identification and collection of baseline data should entail a preliminary evaluation framework with the following specifications:

1. **Identification of evaluation criteria:** these are key result areas (e.g. cost and budget limits, productivity output targets, time schedule) specified in measurable terms;
2. **Selection of evaluation techniques:** apart from the cost benefit analysis, **the use of control groups for comparative analysis**, baseline measures, sampling and various **data gathering methods such as field surveys, focused group discussions (FGD)**, questionnaires and interviews may be chosen.

A typical framework for project evaluation

3. **Time Schedule:** in the case where the project results are not evident immediately after project completion, project evaluation should be scheduled;

4. **Budget for evaluation:** the acquisition and efficient utilization of needed resources for evaluation must be planned for;

5. **Organization and staff requirements:** the size of the evaluation team, its qualifications, the reporting relationships and access to project information and staff should be outlined;

6. **Participation of beneficiaries:** the evaluation process should be designed in such a way that it allows the intended beneficiaries to assume a vital role in it

Steps in Project Evaluation

1. Set Evaluation Questions:

The types of questions can be organized into several general categories such as effectiveness, efficiency, rationale, equity.

2. Identify Who Needs to Know What, and Why:

The chosen questions should relate directly to the information needs of stakeholders, including

- project managers,
- staff,
- board members,
- project sponsors or financiers,
- user community

Steps in Project Evaluation

3. Develop Questions: for example

- Did the project meet its objectives, and if not, where and why did it fall?
- Which lessons and information does the project evaluation provide for policy formation and project management in general?

4. Tracking Outputs and Outcomes: It begins the moment project activities commence.

5. Communications Plan (for Evaluation of Project)

Project Evaluation Steps

- Project evaluation can be broken down into three main types: **pre-project evaluation, ongoing evaluation and post-project evaluation**
- Project evaluation is also critical **to keep stakeholders updated on the project status** and any changes that might be required to the budget or schedule.
- Every aspect of the project such as **costs, scope, risks or profitability** is measured to determine if it's proceeding as planned.
- If there are road bumps, the above data can inform how projects can improve.

Project Evaluation Report

This presents the key findings of project evaluation process.

- Along with methodology, data sources and tools used for evaluation, the **report takes all the results, adds explanations and makes it meaningful for project stakeholders.**
- The contents of evaluation report should be decided while planning for project evaluation so that the right information is collected during the evaluation.
- The focus should be on the outcomes achieved, both intended and unexpected, along with the factors that contributed to or hindered achievement of project outcomes.
- Most importantly, the evaluation report should include conclusions and recommendations on what direction the project should take based on the evaluation results.

Components of the evaluation report

1. The extent to which **articulated objectives are valid**, and the extent to which they were achieved.
2. The extent to which the assumptions upon which the **feasibility study** depended were proven true or untrue as the project was implemented?
3. The **deviation in cost benefit analysis** terms between anticipated results and actual results and the internal and external causes of this deviation;
4. The deviation in the three areas of **time and schedules**, budgets and costs and quantity and quality of productive output; the causes, justified or unjustified, for the deviation;

Components of the evaluation report

5. **The impact of the project on development in general on the intended beneficiaries** in particular; the unintended other impacts and side effects of the project;
6. Prescriptions and recommendations for **continuity, replication, scaling up, or phasing out of post project activity**;
7. **Identification of opportunities for further project** or investment linkages based on elements of generalizability, (that is, those elements with applicability to several projects) recommendations and proposed guidelines for future similar projects and for policy at the project level in general.

A typical structure of evaluation report

- Table of Contents
- Executive Summary
- Introduction
- Findings
- Conclusions
- Recommendations
- Appendices
- Glossary
- References and Credits
- Contact information

Benefits of Project Evaluation

- **Better Project Management:** Project evaluation easily helps in finding areas of improvement when it comes to managing costs, tasks, resources and time.
- **Improves Team performance:** Project evaluation enables keeping track of project team's performance and increases accountability.
- **Better Project Planning:** Helps compare project baseline against actual project performance for better planning and estimating.
- **Helps with Stakeholder Management:** Creating a project evaluation report is very important to keep them updated.
- **Benefits Management:** Accurate assessment of benefits generated by the project

Module VII

Project Termination and Closure

Project communication

- Purpose:** To ensure **everyone is aligned, motivated**, and has the information they need, from initial planning through to final delivery. It is crucial for stakeholder management and team collaboration.
- Process:** Involves strategic planning to determine what information needs to be shared, with whom, when, and in what format.
- Methods:** Utilizes a variety of channels, such as team meetings, status reports, project management software (like [SharePoint](#) or [Microsoft Teams](#)), and the Work Breakdown Structure (WBS).
- Key components:** Effective communication considers both the verbal message and non-verbal cues, the appropriate level of formality, and the chosen medium.

Web-enabled project management

- Web-enabled project management is **the use of web-based software** to manage projects, allowing for **real-time access, collaboration, and tracking of all project activities** from any internet-connected device.
- It centralizes project information, such as **reports, tasks, and communications, making it accessible to all team members** and stakeholders, which helps improve efficiency, decision-making, and accountability.

Key benefits

- **Improved communication:** Provides a central hub for all project communication and documentation, increasing transparency and collaboration.
- **Increased productivity:** Team members can quickly find the information they need to do their jobs, and project managers can make faster, more informed decisions.
- **Better control:** Enables better tracking of time, materials, and budget, and provides real-time visibility into project status to help prevent risks and reduce failures.
- **Enhanced accountability:** Clear task assignment and status updates increase accountability for each team member.

Examples of web-enabled project management software

- **Asana:** Known for its flexibility and task management features
- **Trello:** Uses a simple, visual Kanban board for workflow management.
- **Microsoft Project:** A comprehensive tool for complex planning and resource management.
- **Click Up:** A versatile platform for centralizing tasks, goals, and communication.
- **Monday.com:** A customizable platform for managing workflows and collaborating with teams.

Project management information system

PMIS is a framework that **uses software, tools, and processes** to help **plan, execute, and monitor projects**.

It acts as a central hub for all **project data, such as schedules, budgets, and resources, enabling project managers** to streamline communication, track progress, and make informed decisions.

Examples include software with features like task tracking, resource calendars, and document storage.

Benefits

- **Improved efficiency:** Automates repetitive tasks and centralizes information, leading to better organization.
- **Enhanced communication:** Facilitates seamless collaboration among team members.
- **Informed decision-making:** Provides real-time data for better strategic and tactical decisions.
- **Better cost control:** Helps in managing project budgets and reducing the risk of cost overruns.
- **Risk management:** Helps in identifying and addressing potential problems before they become major constraints.

Example Software:

- Procore**:

A platform for the construction industry that connects office and field teams, with features for budget management, project scheduling, and document sharing.

- InEight**:

Includes project planning, scheduling, cost management, and risk management tools.

- e-Builder**:

A cloud-based system for construction that offers process automation, cost management, and project planning.

- Oracle**:

Provides cloud-based PMIS solutions, particularly for large-scale construction projects.

- Smartsheet**:

A popular PMIS known for its user-friendly interface and automation capabilities.

- Projectmates**:

Offers project scheduling, document management, and cost tracking.

- PMWeb**:

Includes portfolio management, contract management, cost control, and scheduling

Project review meeting

- A formal session held to assess a project's progress, performance, and outcomes to make decisions or capture lessons learned
- It is conducted during a **project at key milestones** to authorize moving to the next step or **at the end of a project to evaluate** what went well and what could be improved.

Points to be reviewed

- Accomplishments:** Major achievements and what went well.
- Performance:** Schedule status, budget performance, and Key Performance Indicators (KPIs).
- Challenges:** Blockers, risks, and issues encountered.
- Financials:** Cash balance, forecast, and profit/loss compared to the plan.
- Action items:** Decisions made on future actions, work-arounds, and new tasks with assigned responsibilities and due dates.
- Team performance:** Evaluation of team and contractor performance.

Purpose:

- Assess progress:**

Evaluate performance against initial targets, budget, and schedule to determine if the project is on track.

- Decide on next steps:**

Give stakeholders or decision-makers the information needed to approve moving to the next phase or milestone.

- Capture lessons learned:**

Discuss what went well and what didn't, documenting best practices and mistakes to avoid repeating them in the future.

- Identify risks and issues:**

Surface and discuss roadblocks, risks, and other challenges that arose during the project.

- Improve future projects:**

Use the insights gained to improve processes and performance in upcoming projects.

- Validate success:**

Determine if the project achieved its intended results and if it should continue to receive resources.

How to conduct a project review meeting

- **Define the objective:**

Clearly state the purpose of the meeting in advance.

- **Create an agenda:**

Plan the topics, allocate time, and prioritize important items to cover early in the meeting.

- **Invite key stakeholders:**

Include the project team, managers, and other relevant stakeholders to get a comprehensive view.

- **Encourage participation:**

Foster a comfortable environment where everyone feels free to ask questions and provide honest feedback.

- **Document and follow up:**

Take minutes, document action items with owners and deadlines, and distribute them to attendees.

Project closure

Project closure is the final phase in software project management, involving **the formal conclusion of all project activities to ensure objectives are met and deliverables are handed over.**

Closing Processes include:

At the end of the entire project, a **final approval from the customer** should be got, followed by,

- **archiving the records** from the project
- Paying **any outstanding** bills
- **compiling the lessons learned**
- Releasing team members
- Closing accounts
- Shutting down facilities
- Writing final reports
- Seek approval from the customer
- Prepare an audit on the success of the project through retrospectives (lessons learned)

The **responsibility of closure lies with the Project Manager** and the team.

Why project closure is important?

- **Ensures completeness:** It provides a **final checkpoint** to ensure all objectives have been met and all necessary tasks are finished.
- **Facilitates continuous improvement:** The lessons learned from a project are a critical input for **improving future project performance**.
- **Optimizes resource allocation:** Releasing resources efficiently allows them to be **utilized for new projects**, increasing organizational agility.
- **Provides formal closure:** It formally concludes the project, which is essential for **moving on to new initiatives** and for all parties to know the project is officially complete.

Key activities in project closure

- Verify and finalize deliverables:** Confirm that all project deliverables, such as the software, meet the agreed-upon specifications, quality standards, and scope.
- Obtain formal acceptance from stakeholders:** Get official sign-off from clients or stakeholders to confirm the project's completion and that it has met its goals.
- Release project resources:** Formally conclude project activities to release project staff, budget, and equipment so they can be redeployed to other tasks.
- Conduct a post-project review and evaluate performance :** Hold a meeting to evaluate project performance, identify what worked well and what could be improved, and discuss lessons learned.
- Document lessons learned for future projects:** Record insights from the project, including any challenges, solutions, and best practices, to inform future projects.
- Archive project documentation:** Collect and store all project-related documents, such as plans, reports, specifications, and meeting minutes, for future reference and as a paper trail.
- Finalize administrative tasks:** Complete all administrative duties, including final project reports, paying invoices, and closing out contracts.

Issues that get discussed during closure

- What were the goals that was set out to achieve?
- How successful was the team in achieving them?
- How effective were the **in-process metrics**? Did it reflect the **end goals**? Is it required to **redefine the metrics** for improvement?
- Where there instances of **over achievement** (was it due to **innovative tasks**?) or **under achievement** (was it due to **unrealistic expectations or poor planning**?) ? If so, what were the root causes?
- Was the size estimation aligned? (in terms of LOC or function points?)
- Was the effort and cost estimation correct?

- What were the factors in the environment that should be changed?
- What is gained out of the system or environment?
- Was the use of communication channels appropriate?
- What was the employee satisfaction in carrying out this project?
- Did the use of any tools ease the process?
- How many originally anticipated risks became realities?
- Was the impact as severe as originally estimated?
- Was the distribution of work fairly made among all team members geographically?
- Is the customer feedback obtained appropriately?

Metrics for project closure

- Size variance
- Effort Variance
- Schedule variance
- Number of changes made to processes- workload distribution, operational procedures, organizational structure
- Software tools enhancements
- Employee satisfaction